Game Story and Gameplay Overview

Oh, RATS!

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Game Story

Oh,RATS! is a strategic tabletop board game set inside a house, where Rats attempt to reach the kitchen and get to the fridge while Cats try to stop them. The game combines movement, strategy, risk taking and player interaction, with a playful cartoon visual style. The board represents different areas of a house, including the living room, bedroom, bathroom, hallways and kitchen.

Players take on the role of either a Rat or a Cat, with each side having different objectives and strategies. The Rats must navigate the house, avoid danger and make their way towards the fridge. The Cats must hunt the Rats, control important areas and use traps to prevent them from reaching their goal.

Gameplay and Objectives

The game is played on a tiled board, with players moving their pieces between tiles. Dice are used to determine movement, introducing an element of chance into each turn. Players must consider their routes carefully, as certain areas may be more dangerous than others.

The Rats main objective is to reach the fridge in the kitchen. Along the way, they may encounter traps, Cats or opportunities to collect useful items. These items could provide advantages during encounters or help the Rats survive their journey. Different Rat characters may also have unique abilities that influence how they move around the board or respond to threats.

The Cats aim to prevent the Rats from reaching the fridge. Rather than simply chasing them, Cat players can make strategic decisions about where to move and when to place traps. Cats will have a limited number of traps, meaning that they must decide where these will be most effective. A Cat might pursue a nearby Rat or move towards a particular area to block a route.

The game is played on a tiled board representing a house, with different areas such as:

- Kitchen
- Living room

- Bedroom
- Bathroom
- Hallways

Movement

Both players move around the board according to a dice roll.

For example:

- Cat rolls 4, moves up to 4 tiles.
- Rat rolls 6, moves up to 6 tiles.

Rats turn:

1. Roll the movement dice.
2. Move the Rat the number of spaces rolled.
3. Check the tile the Rat has landed on.
4. If there is a trap, trigger the trap.
5. If there is a Cat on the same tile, combat occurs.
6. Otherwise, the turn ends.

Cats turn:

1. Rolls the dice.
2. Moves around the house.
3. Can choose to:
    a. Chase the Rat
    b. Place a trap
    c. Move towards a useful area
4. Ends their turn.

Traps and Combat

Traps introduce additional danger and encourage players to think carefully about their movements. If a Rat lands on a tile containing a trap, the trap may cause damage, restrict movement or apply another effect. The current plan is to represent traps as physical game components, with their effects potentially managed through the digital companion.

Combat may occur when a Cat and Rat occupy the same tile. Rather than relying entirely on chance, encounters could involve player choices, cards and dice. Rats might attempt

to fight back, use an item or escape, while Cats try to capture or damage them. Health points would represent each character's remaining health, with the digital companion potentially calculating damage and updating character stats.

The exact combat rules, trap effects and item system will be refined through prototyping and playtesting.

Digital Companion

The project will include a digital companion developed using Svelte and JavaScript. Its purpose is to support and enhance the physical game rather than replace it. Planned features include health tracking, character information and digital responses to gameplay events.

A technical proof of concept has already demonstrated how a QR code can identify a trap and trigger a digital effect, reducing a Rat's health from 10 HP to 5 HP. Further investigation will explore how physical components could interact with the application, including whether NFC could provide a more seamless connection.

Overall Experience

The aim of Oh, RATS! is to create a complete, playable tabletop experience that combines physical components, strategic decision making and digital interaction. Players should feel that they are navigating a dangerous house, making tactical decisions and reacting to unexpected encounters as the Rats attempt to reach the fridge and the Cats try to stop them.